

SECTION SEVEN

HISTORY & LORE

History is not simply background information; it's the weight your characters carry into every scene, every argument, every kiss they shouldn't be having. History is what will explain the reason that families hate each other, why borders were created and why a particular type of magic has been outlawed as well as what it is that people are afraid of. And in romantasy, history is what makes obstacles seem as though they could never be overcome ("we've been enemies for centuries") and when they are overcome, the act of overcoming them means something ("we're ending an ancient war").

The Sediment Principle

Think of your world's history as sediment. Every event, war, betrayal, legendary love affair – these things don't disappear. They compress. One layer on top of another, century after century, they become the ground your characters stand on. Your characters don't see the layers. They just know the ground is solid, that "this is how things are," that certain truths feel as permanent as bedrock.

But bedrock is just old catastrophe, compressed.

It is because of this that history is such a valuable tool in the romantasy genre. Your characters aren't fighting a war. They're fighting the *sediment* of a war that ended three hundred years ago, compressed into family names and border lines and the phrase "we don't trust their kind." They didn't choose to hate each other. They inherited so much hatred from three centuries back it feels like geology. And when they fall in love anyway, they're not just going against their families. They're cracking bedrock.

The deeper the sediment is, the harder it will be to move. A grudge from last year can probably get talked out. But a grudge from five hundred years back has been compressed into identity; it's not something you believe, it's something you *are*. That's why historical enemies-to-lovers is often a better read than personal enemies-to-lovers. The barrier is not something to be clarified or discussed. It's an entire worldview to dismantle.

The Wall in *ACOTAR* is sediment made literal: a physical ward erected after a five-hundred-year-old war, so old by now that Feyre grew up treating it as geography rather than politics. In *Fourth Wing*, the Tyrrish rebellion happened one generation ago, but it's already compressed into identity. Xaden is "a rebel's son" before he's anything else, and he carries the 107 scars that turned a political event into a bodily fact. And in *Mistborn*, the Lord Ruler's ascension happened a thousand years ago and has been compressed into religion, class structure, and the very biology of the skaa. That's the deepest sediment in romantasy; so old it feels like the laws of nature.

You must decide what is underneath your characters' feet, and then let the cracks show.

What sediment are your characters standing on?

The deeper the historical layer, the harder it is to crack. Identify the layers of compressed history beneath your characters' feet, from recent grudges to ancient bedrock.

LAYER	THE EVENT	HOW COMPRESSED IT IS	HOW IT AFFECTS YOUR CHARACTERS
<i>Surface (recent memory)</i>	<i>e.g., Fourth Wing: The Tyrrish rebellion, one generation ago</i>	<i>Still raw — people who fought in it are alive</i>	<i>Xaden is marked by it; Violet's mother ordered it</i>
Surface (recent memory)			
Middle (cultural memory)			
Deep (identity/bedrock)			

How deep is the bedrock your characters need to crack?

The deeper the historical layer, the harder the resolution. A grudge from last year can be talked out. A grudge compressed into identity — “this is what we ARE” — requires dismantling a worldview. Understanding the depth of your central conflict tells you how much your resolution needs to cost.

Is your central historical conflict surface-level (recent, raw, could be resolved with new information), mid-level (cultural memory, woven into traditions and assumptions), or bedrock (so deep it feels like identity, biology, or the laws of nature)?

YOUR ANSWER

What would it take to crack sediment that deep?

YOUR ANSWER

History in Romantasy

History creates romantic obstacles through three mechanisms: inheritance, precedent, and weight. Your characters didn't choose the past, but they're bound by it.

MECHANISM	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES
Inheritance	Family feuds, ancestral crimes, old alliances passed down	"My people and your people have unfinished business"
Precedent	Legendary lovers, previous forbidden romances, prophecies	"Everyone knows how this story ends"
Weight	Breaking from tradition, ending ancient feuds, choosing love over ancestral loyalty	"Choosing you means betraying everything I was raised to be"

The Legendary Lovers Dynamic

Lots of romantasies invoke famous couples from the world's history: doomed lovers, triumphant pairs, cautionary tales. This creates very specific tensions:

HOW IT'S USED	EFFECT
Warning	"Don't repeat their mistake"
Pressure	"Live up to their example"
Doom	"You'll end the same way"
Hope	"If they made it, so can we"
Irony	"The legend got the story wrong"

History Across Romantasy Subgenres

History doesn't function the same way in every kind of romantasy. The subgenre you're writing determines what kind of historical worldbuilding matters most, and what you can afford to leave vague.

SUBGENRE	HOW HISTORY FUNCTIONS	WHAT'S ESSENTIAL	WHAT'S OPTIONAL
Fae court (<i>ACOTAR</i> , <i>The Cruel Prince</i>)	Ancient history as a permanent present; immortal witnesses collapse the distance between past and personal grudge	Ancient foundation conflict; immortal witnesses; rigid court hierarchy	Detailed folkloric accuracy; economic logistics
Military/academy (<i>Fourth Wing</i>)	Institutional memory and state propaganda; the academy controls the narrative and physicalises trauma through rebellion relics	Recent/parental war; institutional propaganda; codified academy rituals	Detailed military strategy; geography and maps
Dark romantasy (<i>From Blood and Ash</i>)	History as a foundational lie; the characters' understanding of reality is fundamentally wrong, and the romance catalyses a theological revolution	The foundational social lie; traumatic personal backstory; predatory ruling class	Detailed pantheon of gods; strict magic system rules

SUBGENRE	HOW HISTORY FUNCTIONS	WHAT'S ESSENTIAL	WHAT'S OPTIONAL
Regency/historical-adjacent (<i>Bridgerton</i>)	Social memory and the stakes of reputation; a single scandal can destroy a family for generations	Class hierarchy (the Ton); reputation and scandal sheets; family legacy and inheritance	Strict historical accuracy; scientific or industrial progress
Vampire/immortal (<i>Twilight</i> , <i>House of Salt and Sorrows</i>)	The individual as a living historical archive; personal memory across centuries creates a disparity between lovers	Subjective longevity; memory disparity (perfect vs. hazy); theological or gothic mythos	Global political context; historical period flavour

The essential takeaway here is that historical worldbuilding in romantasy must prioritise conflict over chronology. The most successful series don't necessarily have the most detailed or logical historical records. They have the most emotionally resonant ones.

Which subgenre pattern does your story follow?

Use the table above to identify your closest match. This tells you where to invest your historical worldbuilding energy — and what you can afford to leave vague. Not every story fits one subgenre neatly; if yours blends two, note both and focus on the “Essential” column for each.

ASPECT	YOUR STORY
Closest subgenre(s)	

ASPECT	YOUR STORY
What's essential for your historical worldbuilding	
What you can leave vague or skip	

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question here will matter for your story. History can stay vague; sometimes “the old war” is enough. Focus on what creates present tension. The question isn’t “what happened?” but “what happened that makes their relationship impossible?” If a section doesn’t apply to you, skip it.

Quick guide to what you need:

- **Enemies-to-lovers rooted in historical conflict?** Focus on: Building Your Timeline (especially Historical Conflicts), Family History & Inherited Wounds, and How People Relate to the Past.
- **Legendary lovers, prophecy, or cyclical doom?** Focus on: Historical Figures & Legendary Lovers (especially Legendary Lovers and Cyclical History).
- **Immortal/mortal romance?** Go straight to: Living History: Long-Lived Beings.
- **Hidden identity or suppressed truth?** Focus on: What Survives, What’s Lost, and What’s Been Hidden (especially Forbidden & Suppressed History).
- **Family opposition or ancestral guilt?** Focus on: Family History & Inherited Wounds (especially Ancestral Legacies and Generational Trauma).

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: The Irrelevant History

Extensive historical detail that never affects the actual story. Elaborate timelines, named kings, detailed battle sequences that exist purely as backdrop. History should create pressure on the present. If your readers can skip the history and miss nothing about why these two characters can't be together, the history isn't doing its job.

FIX

For every historical detail, ask: "How does this affect my characters right now?" If it doesn't create tension, obligation, guilt, fear, or forbidden desire, cut it.

Mistake #2: The Convenient Discovery

Characters discover a hidden historical truth that perfectly solves their problem. "Our peoples have been enemies for centuries" gets resolved by "actually the whole feud was a misunderstanding." If the obstacle dissolves the moment someone finds the right scroll, it was never a real obstacle. The resolution is too easy, and the centuries of suffering feel pointless.

FIX

Historical discoveries should complicate as much as they clarify. In *Mistborn*, discovering the truth about the Lord Ruler doesn't simplify anything; it reveals he was both more sympathetic and more monstrous than anyone believed. In *From Blood and Ash*, Poppy's discovery of Hawke's true identity as Casteel doesn't resolve the conflict between their peoples. It detonates it. The history becomes *more* painful once she knows the full truth.

Mistake #3: The Vague Ancient Grudge

Characters are from feuding families, but the feud is so ancient and vague it has no emotional weight. “Our peoples have always been enemies” without any specificity. Abstract ancient hatred doesn’t create real tension. If neither character can name what was done, the grudge feels like set dressing rather than a wound.

FIX

Make it specific and recent enough to hurt. In *Fourth Wing*, the grudge between Violet and Xaden isn’t “the Tyrnish rebellion.” It’s “your father led the rebellion that got my brother killed.” In *The Cruel Prince*, Jude’s grudge against the fae isn’t ancient and vague. It’s “Madoc murdered my parents in front of me and then raised me.” That specificity is what makes it cut.

Mistake #4: The Static Past

History is just facts to be recited: dates, names, events. Every character agrees on what happened. If both characters share the same version of history, you’ve lost one of your richest sources of conflict. History that everyone agrees on is dead history.

FIX

Give your characters different relationships with the same events. Let them argue about what happened, who was to blame, whether it matters. The past should be as contested between them as the present.

How History Works in Your World

What way your world documents, protects, and shares its history will determine what your characters understand and what they're being lied to about. Whoever manages the documentation of the history will be able to manage the story line and consequently will be able to decide what your characters think of one another's people. A protagonist raised on bardic songs knows a different history than a love interest who read the court archives. This could create an interesting situation when they get together and share their views of history, especially if it is not the romantic type. At least initially.

Think about the inherent unevenness that exists here. In *ACOTAR*, the fae have living witnesses: immortals who personally fought in the war five hundred years ago. Humans have no access to anything except for oral tradition and crumbling records. Feyre's understanding of the war is folklore; Rhysand's is personal memory. Not only are they coming from different sides, they both see the same historical events through completely different perspectives. In *Mistborn*, the Lord Ruler had total control of all recorded history but the oral traditions of the skaa documented a different reality. The way that the past was recorded *was* the battle.

How is history recorded and preserved in your world?

The methods your world uses to document history determine what survives, who has access to it, and what your characters can discover. A world that relies on oral tradition loses details but keeps emotional truth. A world with magical archives preserves everything but restricts access. The method shapes the mystery.

YOUR ANSWER

Which method is considered most authoritative?

What counts as “real” history vs. “just stories”? This matters for your romance. Can your characters dismiss the legend that condemns their love as “just a story,” or does everyone treat it as sacred truth?

YOUR ANSWER

Who Keeps History

Whoever controls the records controls the narrative. Their biases become your world’s “official history,” and official history almost always serves the people who wrote it.

TYPE	WHAT THEY PRESERVE	THEIR BIASES
Court historians	Royal/noble deeds, official narratives	Favour those in power
Religious archivists	Sacred history, moral exemplars	Religious interpretation
Academic scholars	Researched, analytical history	May be detached from lived experience
Bards and storytellers	Popular history, heroic tales	Favour good stories over accuracy
Family keepers	Lineage, family deeds	Favour their own bloodline

Who keeps history in your world?

Focus on the keepers most relevant to your story. Whose version of history do your characters know, and whose version have they never heard?

YOUR ANSWER

What institutions preserve the past?

Institutions that hold history can become plot elements in their own right: libraries to break into, forbidden archives, restricted knowledge that could change everything about what your characters believe.

INSTITUTION	WHAT IT HOLDS	WHO CAN ACCESS IT
<i>Libraries/archives</i>	<i>Chronicles of the realm, treaties, lineage records going back twelve generations</i>	<i>Scholars with royal writ; nobility by right; others by petition and bribery</i>
<i>Magical repositories</i>	<i>Spell grimoires, accounts of magical catastrophes, records of forbidden workings</i>	<i>Only initiated mages; the knowledge inside is considered too dangerous for the uninitiated</i>
<i>Temples/religious centres</i>	<i>Sacred texts, prophecies, records of divine intervention, moral judgments on historical figures</i>	<i>Clergy and initiates; pilgrims may hear selected portions; heretical texts are sealed</i>
<i>Royal/noble collections</i>	<i>Private correspondence, political treaties, family lineage proofs, war spoils</i>	<i>The ruling family and their advisors; others only by royal invitation or theft</i>
<i>Bardic colleges</i>	<i>Songs, epic poems, oral histories preserved in performance; the “popular” version of events</i>	<i>Anyone who attends a performance; but the bardic archives themselves are guarded by tradition</i>

What institutions preserve the past in your world?

Fill in the institutions most relevant to your story. Focus on the ones your characters might need to access — or break into.

INSTITUTION	WHAT IT HOLDS	WHO CAN ACCESS IT

What perspectives are missing from official history?

The conquered? The poor? Certain species? Magic users? The missing perspectives are often where the real story lives, and where your characters might find the truth that changes everything.

YOUR ANSWER

Are there competing versions of history?

Different peoples telling different stories about the same events? One's heroes might be the other's villains. One's glorious victory might be the other's massacre. These aren't lies. They're different truths, and they create conflict that isn't about facts but about perspective.

YOUR ANSWER

How Ordinary People Learn History

Elite record-keeping is one thing, but what do common people actually *know* about the past? This shapes what your characters “know,” and characters raised on songs learn different lessons than characters raised on archives.

How do most people learn about history?

- Stories from elders and family

- Religious teachings
- Songs, ballads, performances
- Festivals commemorating events
- Monuments and public art
- Formal education (if available)
- Gossip and folk memory

Which are most common in your world?

Think about how your characters learned the history they know. Songs? Grandparents' stories? Temple teachings? Two characters who learned history through different channels may "know" completely different pasts.

YOUR ANSWER

What history do children learn?

What stories are they told? What do they grow up "knowing" about the past? The stories children absorb become the beliefs adults struggle to question, even when they fall in love with someone those stories told them to hate.

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a gap between elite and common historical knowledge?

Do scholars know different things than farmers? If your characters come from different classes, they may have been taught fundamentally different histories of the same events.

YOUR ANSWER

Did your protagonist and love interest learn history through different channels?

A character who learned history through bardic songs knows a romanticised version. A character who read court archives knows a politicised version. When they compare what they “know,” the clash isn’t about facts — it’s about whose truth counts. This is a rich source of early-relationship conflict.

CHARACTER	HOW THEY LEARNED HISTORY	WHAT VERSION THEY GOT
Protagonist	<i>e.g., Fourth Wing: Violet learned through military academy propaganda and her mother’s accounts</i>	<i>The rebellion was treason; the loyalists were heroes</i>
Protagonist		
Love Interest		

The way to incorporate history in your writing is by using bits and pieces. Some phrases you hear from everyone. Monuments that are simply walked past without being explained. Old songs with lyrics that no one can remember the words or meaning to. Make history emerge from the things that characters take for granted (“the wall has always been there”), as opposed to telling history as a series of expository statements. If your characters are going to discuss the history, provide them with their own perspectives on it: one calls it “the Great Liberation,” another calls it “the Betrayal.” And some of the most compelling historical moments occur when a character finds out that everything they were ever taught about something was a lie.

What Survives, What’s Lost, and What’s Been Hidden

The things you learn about in history class aren’t all the things that happened in history – some of those things are deliberately forgotten or intentionally destroyed. Gaps in history are where your most dramatic story reveals come from. What your characters do not know will be what hurts them the most. What they find out could completely change their lives.

What survives well in your world?

What survives shapes what your characters can discover — and what secrets stay buried. If only stone monuments survive, the personal histories (love letters, family records, whispered truths) may be lost forever.

Stone buildings? Written records? Magical artifacts? Oral traditions? Bloodline memories?

YOUR ANSWER

What’s been lost?

What kinds of knowledge, artifacts, or records have been destroyed or forgotten?

YOUR ANSWER

Why was it lost?

CAUSE	WHAT WAS LOST
War/conquest	<i>e.g., ACOTAR: Human knowledge of fae culture and the truth of the war was lost when the Wall severed contact between the realms</i>
War/conquest	
Natural disaster	
Deliberate destruction	
Simple neglect/time	

CAUSE	WHAT WAS LOST
Magic (curse, sealing, etc.)	

Are there ruins, artifacts, or fragments that hint at what's lost?

ARE THERE RUINS, ARTIFACTS, OR FRAGMENTS THAT HINT AT WHAT'S LOST?

Does this lost knowledge matter for your story?

If your characters discovered what was lost, how would it change things? Would it dissolve their obstacle, deepen it, or reveal that the obstacle was built on a lie? Lost knowledge matters most when finding it has consequences for the romance.

YOUR ANSWER



How much does your world actually know about its past?

ERA	HOW WELL KNOWN	HOW ACCURATE
<i>Last 50 years</i>	<i>e.g., Fourth Wing: Well known — veterans are still alive</i>	<i>Heavily biased by government propaganda</i>
Last 50 years		
50-200 years ago		
200-500 years ago		
500+ years ago		
Mythic past		

Where does history blur into myth?

At what point does “this happened” become “the stories say”?

YOUR ANSWER

Are there historical “facts” everyone believes that might be wrong?

ARE THERE HISTORICAL “FACTS” EVERYONE BELIEVES THAT MIGHT BE WRONG?

Sometimes the most critical information lies hidden. And when we talk about “hidden history,” that is like having a loaded gun pointed at your characters’ assumptions. Within nearly every romantasy subgenre except for Regency, there exists a fundamental lie that the characters must unmask. In *From Blood and Ash*, the entire kingdom of Solis is based on the myth of the Ascension, and when the protagonists learn that the Ascended are actually predatory vampyric creatures, it destroys all of the assumptions that Poppy ever held. In *Fourth Wing*, the “official history” taught at Basgiath War College is essentially government propaganda intended to keep its own cadets from discovering the true enemy (venin).

Is there a historical truth that’s been suppressed or rewritten?

What would change if your characters discovered the truth? Would it dissolve the obstacle between them, or make it worse?

ASPECT	DETAILS
What really happened	
What people are taught	
Who suppressed it and why	

Who knows the real history?

Everyone but pretends not to? Secret societies? Ancient beings? No one alive?

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters discover this hidden history?

How and when? Historical discoveries should complicate as much as they clarify.

YOUR ANSWER

How does learning the truth change everything?

Does it explain why they're forbidden? Reveal they're not who they thought? Prove that the hatred between their peoples was manufactured?

YOUR ANSWER

Building Your Timeline

You don't have to develop a full timeline of everything that has occurred in your characters' world. You are going to need only the events that caused stress or pressure on your characters' relationships. Your focus needs to be on what will drive the story you want to tell.

Which layers of history matter for your story?

Think about the sediment beneath your characters' feet. Which historical periods — recent memory, cultural memory, deep ancient past — create the most pressure on your romance? You don't need all of them. Focus on the layers that make your characters' relationship feel impossible.

YOUR ANSWER

What's the overall arc of your world's history?

Is your world in decline from a golden age? Rising from ruin? Locked in cycles? Stable but stagnant? The shape of your world's history determines whether your characters' love feels like hope, rebellion, or doom.

YOUR ANSWER

Events from long ago can become legend. They set “the way things have always been,” and they usually give an explanation as to how the current balance of power came to be. Foundational myths and fallen golden ages will influence the beliefs of your characters regarding what is possible, and what is forbidden.

How was your world/nation/society founded?

The origin story as people believe it:

YOUR ANSWER

Who were the founders?

Heroes? Gods? Conquerors? Survivors?

YOUR ANSWER

What ideals did they establish? Are those ideals still honored or corrupted?

The founding ideals shape what your world considers “natural” or “right” — including who is allowed to love whom. If the founders established separation between peoples, your characters’ love is a violation of the founding order itself.

YOUR ANSWER

Was there a golden age that fell?

ASPECT	DETAILS
What it was called	

ASPECT	DETAILS
What made it great	
What caused its fall	
What was lost	

Does the fall relate to your characters' relationship?

Could their union restore what was lost — or repeat the mistake that caused the fall?

YOUR ANSWER



The Defining Event

What single historical event most shaped the current world?

ASPECT	DETAILS
<i>What happened</i>	<i>e.g., ACOTAR: The ancient war between fae and humans</i>
<i>When</i>	<i>Roughly 500 years before the story begins</i>
<i>Who was involved</i>	<i>All fae courts vs. human armies</i>
<i>Immediate consequences</i>	<i>The Treaty; the Wall erected; separation of the realms</i>
<i>Long-term effects still felt today</i>	<i>Humans fear and hate fae; Feyre grows up in poverty partly because the Wall cut off trade; the Treaty's terms still govern fae-human relations</i>
What happened	
When	
Who was involved	
Immediate consequences	

ASPECT	DETAILS
Long-term effects still felt today	

Other Significant Events

List 2-4 other events that matter for your story:

EVENT	WHEN	WHAT HAPPENED	CURRENT RELEVANCE
<i>e.g., The Rite of Culling (ACOTAR)</i>	<i>Centuries ago</i>	<i>Fae courts ritually sacrificed humans to renew the seasonal magic</i>	<i>Humans still fear fae because of ancestral memory of being hunted; Feyre's prejudice is rooted here</i>



Wars and conflicts create deep divisions that will be remembered for centuries to come. Your characters will grow up with knowledge of which side fought against each other, and they may choose their allegiance based upon family history, geography, or the culture in which they were raised.

What major conflicts shaped your world?

CONFLICT	WHO VS. WHO	WHY	WHO WON	LASTING EFFECTS
<i>e.g., The War (ACOTAR)</i>	<i>Fae vs. Humans</i>	<i>Territory and dominance</i>	<i>Fae (enforced the Treaty)</i>	<i>The Wall; human fear of fae; Feyre's inherited prejudice</i>

Are any historical conflicts still unresolved?

Cold tensions, simmering resentments, truces that aren't really peace?

YOUR ANSWER



What major conflict most directly affects your romance?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Name	
When	
Who fought	

ASPECT	DETAILS
Why	
Who won	
Consequences	

Are their families/nations/species on opposing sides of this conflict?

ARE THEIR FAMILIES/NATIONS/SPECIES ON OPPOSING SIDES OF THIS CONFLICT?

Are there still active hostilities, or is this a cold peace?

ARE THERE STILL ACTIVE HOSTILITIES, OR IS THIS A COLD PEACE?

What would it mean for them to be together despite this history?

Betrayal? Healing? Repeating forbidden history?

YOUR ANSWER

Places that have a historical significance have an impact on the lives of your characters. Going back to such places causes the past to be present at that moment; the land remembers just like people do. A battlefield. A throne room where a treaty was signed. The bridge where the legendary lovers met. When your characters stand in those places they are literally standing in the sediment, and the past pushes its way up through their feet.

What historical places matter for your story?

PLACE	WHAT HAPPENED THERE	WHAT IT MEANS NOW	HOW IT AFFECTS YOUR CHARACTERS
<i>e.g., The bridge at Ramiel (ACOTAR)</i>	<i>Ancient rite of passage for Illyrian warriors</i>	<i>Sacred, forbidden to outsiders</i>	<i>Crossing it becomes a test of belonging and worthiness</i>

Do your characters visit a place where history happened?

Why do they go? What do they find? Standing where history happened can force characters to confront what they've been avoiding, or reveal a truth they didn't expect.

YOUR ANSWER

How People Relate to the Past

There are many ways people relate to their own history. Some hold their histories in reverence; some attempt to forget their histories; and some do not consider theirs at all. A couple's views on the past determine how each will perceive their inherited struggle as either a sacred obligation or as simply a bunch of old junk. And when one person falls in love with another with differing views of history, the clash isn't just personal. It's philosophical.

What's your culture's attitude toward the past?

A culture that reveres history treats ancestral feuds as sacred obligations — your characters betray their ancestors by loving each other. A culture that ignores the past makes historical reveals more shocking — nobody expected the old wounds to matter. The attitude determines whether your characters' inherited conflict is a living force or a buried bomb.

Which describes your world (or different groups within it)?

YOUR ANSWER

How do people interact with historical sites?

If ruins are sacred, a romantic scene set in one becomes sacrilege. If they're forbidden, meeting there makes your characters outlaws. The way your world treats its historical places determines what it means for your characters to stand in them together.

Are ruins sacred? Dangerous? Tourist attractions? Forbidden? Looted for materials?

YOUR ANSWER

Do people venerate ancestors?

If your characters' peoples venerate their ancestors, then falling in love with the enemy isn't just a personal betrayal — it's a spiritual one. Ancestor veneration raises the stakes from "my family will be angry" to "my dead grandmother's spirit is watching me betray everything she fought for."

How? Shrines? Prayers? Consulting spirits? Obligation to fulfill their wishes?

YOUR ANSWER

Are there historical commemorations?

Festivals and monuments refresh historical trauma on a schedule. If your world celebrates a victory that was your love interest's people's worst defeat, every anniversary becomes a scene waiting to happen.

Holidays marking past events? Monuments? Annual remembrances?

YOUR ANSWER

Your characters can't merely think of history in terms of stories and memories. Many histories are embedded in the very fabric of the land: monuments, walls, streets named after wars, required rituals, altered texts, even the climate itself. When the government has control over the physical world, the history of the culture becomes indistinguishable from the world itself. Your characters may stroll through the market place, pass by a statue honouring the war which prohibits their love; this is propaganda in its purest form and provides some of the most intense scene-level tension in romantasy. The Wall in *ACOTAR* is the most graphic example: a magical barrier that separates the world into two parts and crackles with energy, leaving the tongue coated with the sensation of division. It's not a metaphor for the fae-human divide. It *is* the divide, and every time a character steps across the Wall they are committing a political act. In *Mistborn*, the propaganda takes on an environmental form: ash falls from the sky covering Scadrial in grey soot. These ash falls were caused by the Lord Ruler's reshaping of the planet, and he was able to erase the memory of green living things from an entire civilisation. Vin's confusion at hearing of green plants is a direct result of the propaganda working exactly as desired. The Steel Ministry is responsible for "soothing stations" located throughout skaa neighbourhoods where Allomancers maintain the mood of the citizens to inhibit rebellion. These stations create physical spaces where the emotional state of the citizens is manipulated, reduced to a level of complacency, thereby making the thought of resistance feel impossible. In *The Cruel Prince*, the topography of Elfhome itself reinforces the social structure of the fae kingdom: the islands are connected by narrow, partially submerged rock paths that require jumping to traverse. This serves as a constant reminder of Jude's mortality compared to the seemingly effortless agility of the fae.

PROPAGANDA TYPE	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES FOR ROMANCE
Physical barriers (walls, wards, borders)	Normalises separation; makes crossing feel transgressive	Every meeting is a political act; the barrier is a “silent witness” to forbidden intimacy
Monumental statuary (statues, portraits, memorials)	Deifies the powerful; makes individuals feel insignificant	Your character walks past a statue of the hero who conquered their lover’s people every day
Mandatory commemorations (festivals, rituals, Victory Tours)	Refreshes historical trauma on a schedule	A celebration of your character’s people’s victory is a mourning of their lover’s people’s defeat
Altered or banned texts	Controls the conceptual boundaries of the past	Characters who find the real text discover the foundation of their enmity is a lie
Environmental propaganda (ashfalls, blighted landscapes, cursed lands)	Makes the consequences of history sensory and inescapable	The world itself reminds your characters of what happened, and whose fault it was
Architectural hierarchy (spires, palaces, slums, restricted zones)	Physicalises the social order	Where your characters are <i>allowed to be</i> in the landscape reflects the power dynamics of the romance

Map your world’s propaganda landscape:

Using the table above as a guide, identify what forms of historical propaganda exist in your world and how they affect your characters’ relationship.

PROPAGANDA TYPE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE IN YOUR WORLD	HOW IT INTRUDES ON YOUR ROMANCE
<i>Physical barriers</i>	<i>e.g., ACOTAR: The Wall separating fae and human territories</i>	<i>Every time Feyre crosses it, she's committing a political act</i>

Does the propaganda landscape intrude on your characters' intimate moments?

Propaganda landscapes are strongest when they enter into the private realm of a character. When Feyre and Rhysand act out their relationship in the Court of Nightmares in *ACOMAF*, it's not just that they're

being forced to perform their love for each other; the court itself is a monument to the violence done to them, and their intimacy becomes political theatre. In *Mistborn*, Vin's first experiences of romance occur at noble balls, where the grey ashfalls outside contrast with the lavish gowns inside. It creates a moral dissonance she can't ignore.

YOUR ANSWER

The way for characters to find resistance is to look for the cracks in the wall, the truth beneath the ash, the banned text that tells a different story. Feyre utilises her own art as a means of resistance, painting vivid, misleading images so that she can keep her real emotions hidden. In *Mistborn*, the truth is literally etched in metal, a medium that can't be altered by the entity who corrupted the paper records. And in *The Hunger Games*, the three-finger salute becomes an organic counter-symbol that outpaces the state's manufactured propaganda.

What “holes” exist in your world's propaganda?

Clandestine meeting places? Forbidden archives? Subversive art? Underground networks? These gaps in the propaganda landscape are where your romance lives. The spaces where the state's version of history fails and something truer can grow.

YOUR ANSWER

Historical Figures & Legendary Lovers

Every history contains its share of legends, its share of demons, and its share of iconic names; your characters exist in those shadows. Heroes build the expectation that others will live up to it. Villains create the lesson for cautionary tales. Legendary lovers create the prototype that your characters are compared to. It's not only a matter of "who came before?" but rather "whose ghost is standing between them?"

Your world's heroes and villains do more than simply fill in a timeline. They establish the standards and expectations your characters are judged against. A protagonist born into a family line of great heroes carries with them the burden of meeting that legacy, and thus the burden of whom they "should" fall in love with. A love interest whose ancestors were your world's greatest villain may carry with them some form of shame that influences all interactions that take place between the two characters. And when one character views another character's hero as a villain? That's not a disagreement. That is a fault line that exists in how each of them sees the world.

Who are the great heroes everyone knows?

Is your protagonist compared to one? Does the love interest idolise someone your protagonist's people consider a villain?

HERO	WHAT THEY DID	HOW THEY'RE REMEMBERED
Eiravel the Undying	United the warring kingdoms; died holding the mountain pass against the demon horde alone	Statues in every city square; invoked before battles; the standard all rulers are measured against
Lady Morgaine Blackthorn	Defied the High Council to save her lover from execution; sparked the Rebellion of Roses	Controversial: traitor to some, symbol of love's power to others; her ballad still sung at weddings

Who are the great villains?

Is either character compared to a villain? What would it mean to be descended from one?

VILLAIN	WHAT THEY DID	HOW THEY'RE REMEMBERED
The Pale King	Broke the ancient compact; unleashed the Blight that killed half the continent	His name is never spoken aloud; his sealed tower still stands, forbidden
Queen Seraphine the Betrayer	Poisoned the peace delegation; murdered her husband to seize sole power	Her portrait hangs reversed in the palace; her descendants changed their names

Are any of these figures relevant to your characters?

Ancestors? Role models? Cautionary examples? One character's hero might be the other's monster.

YOUR ANSWER

Legendary Lovers

Each culture has its legends about love; the great romances, the tragic affairs, the cautionary tales. Your characters may be compared to these legendary couples, expected to follow their path or warned against it. If every body already knows how the story is going to end, then your characters are dealing with the burden of being on a predetermined course as well as facing their own obstacles.

The pressure does not always have to be from a single legendary couple. Sometimes the pressure comes from the repetition of history. The same doomed love story playing out again and again, and everyone watching your characters to see which version plays out next.

What famous love story does your culture tell?

ASPECT	LEGENDARY COUPLE 1	LEGENDARY COUPLE 2 (IF APPLICABLE)
Names		
Their story		
How it ended		
What it teaches		

Is the famous love story tragic, triumphant, or cautionary?

Does your culture celebrate doomed love or warn against it?

YOUR ANSWER

Do people compare your characters to legendary lovers?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Which couple	
Who makes the comparison	
Is it meant as compliment, warning, or accusation	

How do your characters feel about being compared to this couple?

CHARACTER	HOW THEY FEEL ABOUT THE COMPARISON
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

Does the comparison create pressure or expectation?

Are they expected to follow the same path? Avoid the same mistakes?

YOUR ANSWER

What do your characters know about the legendary couple that others don't?

Is the famous story accurate? Romanticized? Missing crucial context?

YOUR ANSWER

Does history repeat in your world?

Cyclical history creates a specific kind of romantic dread: the sense that your characters are walking a path others have walked before, and everyone watching knows how it ended. Are there patterns, prophecies, or recurring doom that your characters are expected to repeat?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a historical parallel to your characters' situation?

A previous pair of lovers from opposing sides? A past relationship that ended in tragedy?

ASPECT	DETAILS
What happened before	
How it ended	

Do people compare your characters to this historical precedent?

DO PEOPLE COMPARE YOUR CHARACTERS TO THIS HISTORICAL PRECEDENT?

Are they doomed to repeat history, or determined to break the cycle?

ARE THEY DOOMED TO REPEAT HISTORY, OR DETERMINED TO BREAK THE CYCLE?

What would breaking the cycle require?

WHAT WOULD BREAKING THE CYCLE REQUIRE?



Having famous ancestry can create expectations and obligations. Inheriting a legendary role means living in someone's shadow, and that shadow falls over the relationship too. If the last person who held your character's position loved unwisely and caused a catastrophe, everyone will be watching to see if your character makes the same mistake. If their ancestor was the one who ended the last forbidden romance, there's a grim irony in your character falling into one. The legend doesn't have to be about love to distort a love story, either. A military hero's descendant may feel obligated to put duty first, and a traitor's descendant may feel they don't deserve love at all.

Is either character descended from a famous historical figure?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Which character	
Descended from	
What's expected of them	

Does either character hold a position once held by someone legendary?

Did the predecessor succeed or fail? Love or lose?

ASPECT	DETAILS
The position	
Who held it before	
What that predecessor did	

ASPECT	DETAILS
The shadow this casts	

How does living in a legend's shadow affect your character?

Do they try to live up to it? Rebel against it? Feel crushed by impossible expectations? Does the legend's story make their own love feel inevitable, or doomed?

YOUR ANSWER

Family History & Inherited Wounds

Beyond big events, every family has its own stories. Stories told by the fire side, legends of ancestors and grievances passed down through generations help shape identity for people. They tell you who your people are, what values to have, who to hate or honour. When two people fall in love their family stories either align or clash, and that clash is where the tension lives.

Allow your family stories to naturally emerge in your writing, triggered by objects, places, or moments. A character picks up their grandmother's ring and remembers the story of how she survived the siege. They pass an old oak and mention that is where their father proposed. Don't give the full story right away; let details accumulate over time. The strength of the family story is in how it has been developed over time through retellings: what has been emphasised, what has been softened, what has been left out. When characters share family stories with one another it is an act of intimacy. They're saying "this is where I come from, this is who my people are." And when family stories collide ("your great-grandfather killed my ancestor") they create conflicts that feel both ancient and deeply personal.

Family Stories

What stories does your protagonist's family tell about themselves?

The founding ancestor? The great hero? The terrible loss? The family shame? These stories shape who your characters believe they should be.

YOUR ANSWER

What stories does your love interest's family tell?

Their family stories may complement, contradict, or directly oppose your protagonist’s family mythology.

YOUR ANSWER

How do these family stories shape who each character believes they should be?

CHARACTER	WHAT FAMILY STORIES TAUGHT THEM TO BE
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

Are there family stories that contradict each other?

Does one family’s hero appear as a villain in the other’s stories?

YOUR ANSWER

What family story has each character never questioned, until now?

Falling in love with the “wrong” person often forces us to question the stories we were raised on.

YOUR ANSWER



If your characters come from different backgrounds, do they know different histories?

EVENT	PROTAGONIST'S VERSION	LOVE INTEREST'S VERSION
<i>e.g., The Tyrrish Rebellion (Fourth Wing)</i>	<i>A treasonous uprising that cost loyal soldiers their lives</i>	<i>A justified fight for independence that was crushed by a tyrant</i>

What happens when they compare histories?

Do they fight about it? Try to understand? Discover they were both taught incomplete versions?

YOUR ANSWER

What would it mean if the “other side’s” history turned out to be true?

WHAT WOULD IT MEAN IF THE "OTHER SIDE'S" HISTORY TURNED OUT TO BE TRUE?

What major event happened within living memory (last 50-80 years)?

ASPECT	DETAILS
The event	

ASPECT	DETAILS
When	
Who fought/suffered/benefited	
How it shaped the current world	

How did this event affect your characters' families?

CHARACTER	HOW THEIR FAMILY WAS AFFECTED
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

Were their families on the same side or opposing sides?

WERE THEIR FAMILIES ON THE SAME SIDE OR OPPOSING SIDES?

Does this recent history create conflict between them?

Do their families still hate each other? Is one family blamed by the other?

YOUR ANSWER

Heirlooms & Objects

Objects of the past can hold many things – weapons that killed, rings that bound, letters that told the truth. Objects can turn history into reality and force characters to have to deal with their past in a physical sense, and not just an emotional one.

What object from the past does your protagonist possess or know about?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Object	
Its history	
What it means to them	

What about your love interest?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Object	
Its history	
What it means to them	

Is there an object that connects both their histories?

Something stolen, shared, or fought over? Something that proves a historical truth?

YOUR ANSWER

Could an heirloom help or hurt their relationship?

Does it prove something? Reveal something? Obligate them to enemies?

YOUR ANSWER



More than just wealth, your characters will also inherit their family name, reputation, obligations, and sometimes curses. The reputation of a name carries weight, the expectations of a bloodline carry weight, and the union of two specific bloodlines has the potential to be the harbinger of a prophecy.

What did your protagonist's ancestors do that affects them now?

Great deeds? Terrible crimes? Sacred oaths? Curses earned?

YOUR ANSWER

What reputation does their family name carry?

WHAT REPUTATION DOES THEIR FAMILY NAME CARRY?

What obligations do they inherit?

Oaths to serve? Debts to repay? Vengeance to seek?

YOUR ANSWER

What did your love interest's ancestors do that affects them now?

WHAT DID YOUR LOVE INTEREST'S ANCESTORS DO THAT AFFECTS THEM NOW?

What reputation does their family carry?

WHAT REPUTATION DOES THEIR FAMILY CARRY?

Do ancestral legacies put them in conflict?

Historical enemies? One family wronged the other?

YOUR ANSWER

Does bloodline matter in your world?

Magically? Politically? Socially? Bloodline significance creates stakes for who your characters are *allowed* to love, and what happens if forbidden bloodlines combine.

YOUR ANSWER

What does each character's bloodline mean?

CHARACTER	HERITAGE AND WHAT IT GRANTS OR DEMANDS
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

Is there something significant about combining their bloodlines?

Prophecy fulfilled? Forbidden mixing? Powerful heirs? Ending a curse?

YOUR ANSWER

Historical pain doesn't stay in the past. It lives in families, in bodies, in how people react to certain words or places. Your character can be carrying around grief, fear, or rage because of things that happened to relatives they've never known. And some events are too terrible to be simply "past." Atrocities leave marks that last for generations and raise questions as to whether it is even possible to forgive.

In *Fourth Wing*, this is made literal: Xaden has 107 scars on his back, one for every child of the rebellion leaders whose survival he bargained for. His scars are a relic of the rebellion, a constant visual reminder that the Tyrrish conflict isn't abstract history but something carved into his body. Violet grew up as the daughter of the woman who ordered his father's execution. They're on opposite sides of the same wound, and their romance requires navigating that without either minimising the other's pain. In *ACOTAR*, the asymmetry is different: Feyre has the inherited fear and dehumanisation of fae that all humans were conditioned to feel through generations of being preyed upon. Rhysand carries centuries of watching humans be dismissed as lesser. Their trauma is asymmetric. They both suffered the same historical wounds, but in different ways.

What historical trauma does your protagonist carry?

Not what they personally experienced, but what their family, people, or community carries.

YOUR ANSWER

How does this trauma manifest?

Fear? Hatred of certain groups? Hypervigilance? Stories that haunt? Places they can't go? Trauma shows in behaviour: avoidance, triggers, fierce protectiveness, distrust of certain people.

YOUR ANSWER

What historical trauma does your love interest carry?

Their trauma may complement, mirror, or directly conflict with your protagonist's inherited wounds.

YOUR ANSWER

How does it manifest in them?

The same historical wound can show up as rage in one character and silence in another. How does the love interest's inherited trauma shape their behaviour, especially toward people from the protagonist's side of history?

YOUR ANSWER

If their traumas come from the same event but opposite sides, how do they navigate that?

One's ancestors were perpetrators, the other's were victims? Both were victims of different aggressors? This is one of the most complex emotional obstacles in enemies-to-lovers romance.

YOUR ANSWER

Can historical wounds be healed, or are they permanent?

What would healing require? Acknowledgment? Apology? Justice? Time?

YOUR ANSWER

Did either side in historical conflicts commit atrocities?

Atrocities create wounds that don't heal with time. They raise questions of guilt, responsibility, and whether forgiveness is possible.

ASPECT	DETAILS
What happened	
Who committed them	
Who suffered	

How is this remembered?

Perpetrators and victims remember differently. Understanding both perspectives deepens your enemies-to-lovers tension.

GROUP	HOW THEY REMEMBER
By the perpetrators	
By the victims	

Is this atrocity acknowledged, denied, justified, or forgotten?

How society handles atrocity shapes whether your characters can discuss it openly or must navigate denial and silence.

YOUR ANSWER

Does one character carry guilt for ancestors' actions? Does the other carry rage for ancestors' suffering?

Inherited guilt and rage ("I didn't do this, but my people did" and "you didn't suffer this, but my people did") create one of the most layered emotional obstacles in romantasy.

YOUR ANSWER

History as a Weapon

All of the worldbuilding that has been done to this point occurs *beneath* the surface of the story. But on the page, historical conflict shows up in one particular way: characters weaponise the past during arguments, betrayals, and emotional standoffs. They reduce each other to representatives of an oppressive regime or a biologically inferior species. They use “the sins of the father” as a trump card to shut down vulnerability. They retreat into inherited grievance because it’s safer than admitting they feel something.

That is where your historical worldbuilding earns its keep. If the history you’ve built doesn’t give your characters ammunition to throw at each other during their worst moments, it’s not doing enough.

Characters don’t just *feel* historical enmity. They *use* it. The past becomes a defensive mechanism: a means of maintaining psychological distance, a justification for betrayal, a method for ending an argument they’re losing. When the present becomes too emotionally dangerous, the past gets thrown like a grenade.

WEAPON TYPE	HOW IT WORKS	EXAMPLE
The name as a slur	A character’s family name or heritage is used to reduce them to their ancestors’ crimes	<i>Fourth Wing</i> : Xaden uses “Sorrenghail” as shorthand for everything the loyalists did to his people; Violet can’t escape her mother’s legacy
Biological othering	A character’s species or mortality is invoked to deny their worth or belonging	<i>The Cruel Prince</i> : Cardan and the Gentry call Jude “mortal,” reducing her identity to a biological fact that means she’s temporary and lesser

WEAPON TYPE	HOW IT WORKS	EXAMPLE
The historical trump card	A character invokes a specific ancestral crime to shut down the argument	<i>ACOTAR</i> : Rhysand's mother and sister were slaughtered by Tamlin's father and brothers, a history that functions as a permanent wedge, thrown in Tamlin's face to justify the Night Court's refusal to trust him
Protection as control	A character uses the historical vulnerability of the other's people to justify limiting their autonomy	<i>ACOTAR</i> : Tamlin weaponises Feyre's human fragility and the looming war with Hybern to justify locking her in the Spring Court. His "protection" becomes a continuation of her imprisonment
Inherited identity as accusation	A character is held responsible for what their people did, regardless of their personal choices	<i>Fourth Wing</i> : Violet enters the Riders Quadrant as the daughter of the woman who ordered Xaden's father's execution. She is a Sorrengail before she's anything else
Turning the weapon back	A character accepts the history thrown at them and uses it as strength	<i>The Cruel Prince</i> : Jude tells Madoc "I am what you made me," accepting the ruthlessness he taught her and using it to dismantle his coup

The Mirror Effect

There is a fascinating theme here. Characters do not actually weaponise history against their opposites. They weaponise it against those who are most like them. A historical grievance attacks the aspects of the self which the character has yet to accept. In *Fourth Wing*, Xaden can see his own rebel heart in Violet's stubborn will, and his weaponisation of their opposing histories is a desperate attempt to avoid recognising how much they have in common. In *Bridgerton*, Anthony and Kate use their ancestral responsibilities as shields, each accusing the other of being too protective, too dutiful, because they're terrified of admitting they're the same kind of person.

The best history-as-weapon scenes occur when a character uses the past to throw at another character at a time of great emotional vulnerability, and the second character does not retreat. Jude spitting "Never" at Cardan in the river. Violet touching Xaden's scars instead of recoiling. Poppy stabbing Casteel after his identity reveal. The weapon is drawn, and instead of it ending the scene, it transforms it. The hostility changes into something rawer, more exposed, more dangerous than hatred. The resolution doesn't come from the weapon being taken away. It comes from one character refusing to flinch.

What does their historical weapon reveal about the attacker?

The Mirror Effect means characters use the past to attack traits they recognise in themselves. The accusation they throw is a window into what they're most afraid of being. Map the mirror: what does each character accuse the other of, and how is that accusation actually a confession?

CHARACTER	THE HISTORICAL ACCUSATION THEY MAKE	THE TRAIT THEY'RE ACTUALLY ATTACKING	WHY THEY RECOGNISE IT (THE MIRROR)
Protagonist	<i>e.g., Fourth Wing: Violet distrusts "rebel's sons" and anyone who'd betray the system</i>	<i>Disloyalty</i>	<i>She's already rebelling against her mother's expectations — she IS disloyal, and it terrifies her</i>
Protagonist			

CHARACTER	THE HISTORICAL ACCUSATION THEY MAKE	THE TRAIT THEY'RE ACTUALLY ATTACKING	WHY THEY RECOGNISE IT (THE MIRROR)
Love Interest			

Your Characters' Arsenal

What historical ammunition does your protagonist carry?

What can they throw at the love interest during their worst arguments? Their family name? Their people's crimes? Their species' history of oppression?

ASPECT	DETAILS
The weapon	
When they use it	
What it's really about (the fear underneath)	

What historical ammunition does your love interest carry?

What's their trump card? What historical fact can they invoke that the protagonist has no answer for?

ASPECT	DETAILS
The weapon	
When they use it	
What it's really about (the fear underneath)	

What happens when the weapons are drawn?

Does the scene escalate (like Poppy stabbing Casteel) or resolve (like Violet accepting Xaden's scars)? Escalation drives the plot forward; resolution builds intimacy. Both are powerful, and the best romances alternate between them.

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a moment where one character refuses to flinch?

This is often the turning point of the entire romantic arc. The weapon is drawn, the historical accusation is made, and instead of retreating, the other character steps closer. That's when history stops being a wall and starts becoming a door.

YOUR ANSWER

The History Reveal

A character can give another person their history as either a weapon or as a gift. Or as a test. When a character gives another person their history – especially if that history is painful, embarrassing, or goes against what the other has been told – and they do so voluntarily, that is probably one of the most compelling romantic moments in romantasy. This is basically the opposite of using history to keep someone out of your life. Instead of using the past to push someone away, the character is giving someone a way to get closer to them. And what the listener does after hearing the history is what determines whether the relationship grows or dies.

There are two common ways that these moments play out:

The repair confession. When a character finally reveals some piece of withheld information that changes the reader’s understanding of the character’s actions, converting ambiguity into coherence. In *ACOMAF*, when Rhysand tells Feyre what happened Under the Mountain, he goes from being “the manipulative and dangerous High Lord” to “a person who did bad things for good reasons to protect people he loves.” The reason for the confession was due to friction in their relationship (Feyre’s anger at being kept in the dark). It takes place in a small, private space, and is followed immediately by Feyre retreating to a remote cabin to collect herself. No reconciliation occurs immediately. Because she is allowed to process the new information at her own pace, she is able to eventually reconnect to Rhysand on her own terms, which is why the final connection feels like it occurred organically and not out of obligation.

Xaden’s scars confession in *Fourth Wing* follows a similar structure. It happens after an intimate moment, when Violet reaches out to touch the scars on Xaden’s body and asks him to explain the

meaning behind them. He shares that each of the 107 scars represents a child whose life he saved by making a political deal: one scar for each child. Violet does not react to this as political trivia, but as an embodied expression of suffering. She responds with tender touch and protection, rather than horror. This way, the history-sharing feels like a demonstration of intimacy rather than a dumping of background information.

The identity rupture. The identity rupture is when you reveal something that ruins the listener's whole view of reality and causes them to go on the defence versus creating closeness. In *From Blood and Ash*, Poppy learns that her "boyfriend," Hawke, is actually Prince Casteel Da'Neer, the person she was taught to hate when growing up. When she discovers this truth during a medical emergency, her consent framework is instantly tainted by the fact that she chose intimacy with someone who didn't exist. The relationship cannot go back to what it was before. In *The Cruel Prince*, the revelation is less about a confession from Cardan and more about Jude being an observer to his abuse at the hands of Balekin. She gains access to his history without permission, creating ethical problems surrounding the nature of their relationship. She may use the information to gain his pity, to manipulate him for her own purposes, or to protect herself. The shift to a different kind of intimacy does not happen right away. It is up to Jude to decide how to proceed.

The best scenes that show a history-reveal are all structured similarly: a trigger (a question, a crisis, a boundary that must be explained), the actual revelation (this must be clear, cost the speaker dearly, and take place in a private, confined area), the listener's response to that revelation (the listener's response must be observable – the listener touches them, the listener withdraws from them, the listener gets angry, the listener makes a new promise – as opposed to only internal), and a changed relational dynamic that shifts the way the two people relate to each other. Location is also incredibly important here. Beds, isolated cabins, and automobiles (*Twilight's* car-ride confession) serve as "truth chambers" because they are small, private, and have eliminated public performance. Ideally, you want to put your reveal close enough to a point where the reader can see evidence of the character's concern for the other person, yet far enough away so that the larger issues of the story can still explode later. And crucially, the listener should never have to forgive the speaker immediately after learning this information. The most compelling revelations provide the listener with the opportunity to reflect on the experience: withdrawal that looks like choice and not rejection.

Does your story include a history-reveal scene?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Which character reveals?	
What history do they share?	
What triggers the reveal? (crisis, intimacy, accusation, discovery)	
Where does it happen? (the “confessional container”)	
How does the listener react? (touch, withdrawal, anger, reassessment)	
Does it bring them closer or drive them apart?	

ASPECT	DETAILS
Is it a repair confession or an identity rupture?	

Map the structure of your history-reveal scene:

The best reveals follow a specific architecture. Use the prose above to check that your reveal has all the structural elements that make it land.

ELEMENT	YOUR SCENE	CHECK
The trigger (what forces the reveal)		
The confessional container (where it happens — small, private, public performance eliminated)		
The cost to the speaker (what it costs them to share this)		

ELEMENT	YOUR SCENE	CHECK
The listener's observable response (not just internal — what do they DO?)		
The changed dynamic (how do they relate differently after?)		
Space to process (does the listener get to withdraw and choose to return?)		

If the reveal backfires, what replacement frame must the text supply?

A reveal that violates the listener's beliefs can only be survived if the story provides a new ethical frame: a reason the speaker hid truth (safety, coercion, wartime necessity) and a path for the listener to regain agency (the choice to stay, fight, or forgive). Without this, the romance feels coercive rather than earned.

YOUR ANSWER

Reconciling with History

Building tension is one thing; resolving it is much harder. One of the most common failures of the historically-rooted enemies-to-lovers trope is the reconciliation that feels too simple: either a revelation that causes the feud to dissipate quickly, or a single conversation that ends hundreds of years of animosity. If you have created a historical conflict strong enough to keep your lovers apart for the majority of your book, then you need to create an equally powerful resolution.

Earned reconciliations are the ones that create closure on many different levels: emotionally (the lovers get together), thematically (the meaning of the conflict shifts), and structurally (the world changes). Simply having the lovers reconcile personally – they come together, but the war is still raging and nothing has changed about the structures of society – will leave your readers feeling shortchanged. The heart and the world need to be transformed together.

REQUIREMENT	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT HAPPENS WITHOUT IT
Reciprocal sacrifice	Both characters give up a portion of their historical privilege or identity	The reconciliation feels one-sided; one character does all the changing
Time and pacing	Prejudice erodes gradually through shared experience and small moments of vulnerability	The resolution feels rushed; centuries of bias vanish overnight
A shared enemy or shared truth	Something renders the old enmity obsolete or reframes it entirely	Characters seem to betray their people rather than transcend the conflict
Public and private resolution	Private acts of vulnerability build personal trust; public acts address the historical identity	The love story feels isolated from the world; nothing changes outside the bedroom

REQUIREMENT	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT HAPPENS WITHOUT IT
Structural change	The world order shifts alongside the relationship	Readers feel “robbed”; the characters are happy but the injustice continues

Pacing the Resolution

Historical hatreds are seldom broken down by one incident. The best earned reconciliations are slow burn paced; when shared peril brings individuals together, cracks in the armour begin to develop. A time when either side realises an act of kindness or courage from the opposing side that contradicts how they view their enemy. Jude and Cardan’s relationship in *The Cruel Prince* is formed through mutual double-crossing and betrayal, so when Jude ultimately trusts Cardan, it is a reward for their prolonged efforts rather than a quick plot fix. In *The Serpent and the Wings of Night*, Oraya and Raihn build trust through the crucible of a deadly tournament and learn to trust each other’s skills before they will ever trust each other’s hearts.

Another hazard is the “easy epiphany,” the single moment when all of the prejudices that have existed for centuries just melt away. *Mistborn* has been criticised for using a Cinderella analogy to facilitate Vin and Elend’s cross-class reconciliation; many readers feel that the gradual emotional progression needed to bring about such a great systemic change was missing from the story.

Feyre’s role as the new High Lady of Prythian is used to symbolise the end of the fae-human divide in *ACOTAR*. Similarly, in *The Bridge Kingdom*, Lara must go on a military mission to free Aren and his kingdom before she can regain the lost trust she had caused with her betrayal. While private love may be a necessity, the public must also witness the changes. It is not enough to create a new dynamic between people if society never sees the evidence of it.

A reconciliation that comes at no cost is unearned. The cost could include exile, losing a family member, changing who you once were or realising your people were wrong. The larger the historical weight, the larger the price tag should be.

How does your romance resolve the historical conflict?

The reconciliation between your characters needs to work on multiple levels. If they get together personally but the world doesn’t change, readers feel cheated. Map how you’re planning to earn it.

REQUIREMENT	HOW YOUR STORY MEETS IT
<i>Reciprocal sacrifice</i>	<i>e.g., ACOTAR: Feyre gives up her human life; Rhysand gives up his secrecy and isolation</i>
Reciprocal sacrifice	
Time and pacing	
A shared enemy or shared truth	
Public and private resolution	
Structural change	

Map your slow-burn progression:

Reconciliation doesn't happen in one scene. It happens through a sequence of small moments where the armour cracks. List 3-5 moments where your characters' inherited enmity erodes — shared danger, unexpected kindness, a moment where one sees the other's humanity despite everything they were taught.

MOMENT	WHAT HAPPENS	WHAT CRACK IT CREATES
<i>e.g., Fourth Wing: Xaden saves Violet during the Gauntlet</i>	<i>He protects someone he's supposed to hate</i>	<i>Violet can't reconcile "rebel's son" with the person who saved her life</i>
1.		
2.		
3.		
4.		
5.		

What does reconciliation cost your characters?

A reconciliation that comes at no cost is unearned. The larger the historical weight, the larger the price tag. What do your characters lose, sacrifice, or fundamentally change about themselves in order to be together?

CHARACTER	WHAT THEY SACRIFICE OR LOSE
<i>Protagonist</i>	<i>e.g., The Bridge Kingdom: Lara loses her family's trust and her identity as a spy; she must fight to free the kingdom she helped destroy</i>
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

Living History: Long-Lived Beings

The fact that immortals and ancient beings have a personal connection to the past, by way of having lived through the same time period, collapses the distance between past and present. An ancient character doesn't learn about the old war – the character was there. They fought in it. And when they fall in love with someone mortal, the contrast between the two is extreme. The former has hundreds of years of background and context to draw upon, while the latter has only the single, short, vibrant experience of a mortal life.

This “emotional stasis,” or lack of emotional aging, is an almost defining characteristic of the fae court romantasy subgenre. Historical events can become traumatic experiences that remain intensely personal and therefore can be directly tied to the romantic arc. Rhysand is personally connected to the war that created the Wall, not simply as a participant, but as a fighter who suffered losses during the conflict. All decisions that he makes based on politics are fuelled by the same anger and sense of loss that he felt centuries ago. Edward Cullen's ability as a vampire to recall all of his moments since becoming a vampire is due to the clarity and perfection of his immortal memory, while his human memories are fading and indistinct. As a vampire that has been alive for over one hundred years,

Edward is stuck in time. His relationship with Bella forces him to confront the stark difference between his crystalline immortal memory and her very brief, intense, mortal experience. And in *Shadow and Bone*, the Darkling has lived for centuries and has watched as Sun Summoners came and went. Alina Starkov is another Sun Summoner, and unlike the many others that came before her, she refuses to play out the role assigned to her.

Is either of your characters a long-lived being?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Which character	
How old	
What history they've lived through	

If one character is ancient and one is mortal, how does this affect the relationship?

The ancient character has seen patterns repeat, loved and lost countless times, watched mortal lives flicker past. The mortal character is one brief moment in an endless existence, or perhaps they're something different, something that makes the ancient one feel again.

The ancient character:

QUESTION	ANSWER
What historical patterns have they seen repeat?	
What have they lost over centuries?	
What makes them cynical, or gives them hope?	
Do they see the mortal as another loss waiting to happen?	

The mortal character:

QUESTION	ANSWER
What does it mean to love someone who's seen centuries?	
Do they feel insignificant? Or do they bring something the ancient one has lost?	

QUESTION	ANSWER
Are they aware of their own mortality in the relationship?	

What does the long-lived character carry from their past?

Lost loves? Dead friends? Guilt? Witnessed atrocities? Actions they regret?

YOUR ANSWER

How does their personal history affect the relationship?

Are they afraid to love again? Comparing the mortal to past loves? Keeping secrets from centuries ago?

YOUR ANSWER

Integration Check

QUESTION	ANSWER	EXAMPLE
How does history justify current government?		<i>ACOTAR</i> : The Wall and Treaty, born from the ancient war, justify the separation of fae and human territories and the High Lords' authority
How does history explain religious beliefs?		<i>Mistborn</i> : The Lord Ruler's ascension became the basis of the Steel Ministry's religious authority
How does history create cultural attitudes and taboos?		<i>The Priory of the Orange Tree</i> : Ancient dragonrider history shapes which cultures revere vs. fear dragons
How did magic change history?		<i>Shadow and Bone</i> : The creation of the Shadow Fold reshaped Ravkan politics and borders for centuries
Could understanding history change how people view your characters' relationship?		<i>Romeo and Juliet</i> : If the feud's origin were revealed as trivial, it would reframe the tragedy

Quick Reference

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD	EXAMPLE
The historical conflict that affects your romance		<i>ACOTAR</i> : The ancient war between fae and humans
Protagonist's ancestral legacy		<i>Six of Crows</i> : Inej's Suli heritage and the cultural weight of her family's traditions
Love interest's ancestral legacy		<i>ACOTAR</i> : Rhysand's family legacy as High Lord, the weight of the Night Court's history
The legendary lovers they're compared to		<i>The Cruel Prince</i> : Echoes of past human-fae romances that ended in betrayal
The historical parallel (past situations that mirror theirs)		<i>Priory of the Orange Tree</i> : Ancient dragonrider bonds that mirror the protagonists' connection
The suppressed truth (if any)		<i>Mistborn</i> : The true history of the Lord Ruler's ascension, hidden for a thousand years
The historical pattern (cycle they're repeating or breaking)		<i>Shadow and Bone</i> : The Darkling's repeated pattern of seducing Sun

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD	EXAMPLE
		Summoners across centuries
How history resolves		<i>ACOTAR</i> : The Wall falls; the old separation ends; a new era begins

Final Thought

Without history, your characters' choices are made in a void. With history, each of your characters' choices can either continue a cycle or break it. A 500-year feud gives weight to reconciliation. "My ancestor killed yours" makes forgiveness costly. Make a history so that your characters will think that the current state of affairs is as destined as anything can be; then allow them to show us how the future doesn't have to be.